

Meridian State University

Library Services Handbook

Borrowing Privileges, Research Support, and Facility Access

Document Code: LIB-HBK-310

Effective Date: August 1, 2026

Issuing Office: Office of the Registrar & Academic Affairs

Review Cycle: Annual

1. Welcome to the University Libraries

The Meridian State University Libraries system comprises the Carrington Main Library, the Science & Engineering Library, the Fine Arts Reading Room, and the 24-hour Innovation Commons. Together these facilities hold over 1.4 million print volumes, 220,000 e-books, and subscriptions to more than 48,000 electronic journals, in addition to extensive digital archives and media collections.

This handbook describes borrowing privileges, facility access, research support services, and the policies that keep library resources available and equitable for the entire campus community.

2. Borrowing Privileges

Patron Category	Loan Period	Item Limit	Renewals
Undergraduate Students	21 days	40 items	3 (if not requested by another patron)
Graduate Students	60 days	75 items	5
Faculty	One semester	150 items	Unlimited while in use
Staff	28 days	30 items	3
Alumni (Library Card Holders)	14 days	10 items	2
Reserve/Course Materials	2 hours – 3 days	As assigned by instructor	None

Items may be renewed online through the library catalog, provided no other patron has placed a hold. Overdue fines accrue at \$0.25 per day for general circulation items and \$2.00 per hour for reserve materials, up to the replacement cost of the item.

3. Interlibrary Loan and Document Delivery

Materials not held in the University's collection may be requested through Interlibrary Loan (ILL). Standard turnaround time is 5–10 business days for physical items and 1–3 business days for scanned articles and book chapters, delivered electronically at no charge to the requester. Graduate students and faculty engaged in thesis, dissertation, or funded research may request expedited processing through their subject librarian.

4. Research and Instruction Services

3.1 Subject Librarians

Each academic college is supported by a dedicated subject librarian who provides one-on-one research consultations, curates discipline-specific databases, and delivers in-class information literacy instruction. Consultations may be booked online and are available in person, by video, or by phone.

3.2 Citation and Writing Support

The Library operates a Citation Help Desk offering guidance on APA, MLA, Chicago, and IEEE citation styles, as well as citation management software including Zotero, EndNote, and Mendeley. Workshops are held weekly during the fall and spring semesters.

5. Study Spaces and Facility Access

- Individual study carrels are available on a first-come, first-served basis on Levels 2 through 4 of the Main Library.
- Group study rooms (12 total) may be reserved online up to 7 days in advance, for a maximum of 3 hours per booking.
- The Innovation Commons is accessible 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, to currently enrolled students with a valid University ID.
- Quiet study floors (Levels 3–4) prohibit phone calls and group conversation; collaborative work is directed to Level 1 or the Innovation Commons.

6. Technology and Equipment Lending

The Library circulates laptops, graphing calculators, DSLR cameras, portable scanners, and charging cables for short-term loan. Laptops circulate for a 4-hour in-library use period or a 7-day external loan for students who submit a Technology Equity Loan application, prioritized for students with demonstrated financial need.

7. Accessibility Services in the Library

The Library maintains an Adaptive Technology Lab on Level 1, equipped with screen-reading software, adjustable-height workstations, Braille embossers, and large-print reading equipment. Students registered with the Office of Accessibility Services may request extended loan periods, priority scanning of course reserves into accessible formats, and a dedicated liaison librarian to assist with research accommodations.

Requests for materials in alternative formats should be submitted at least 10 business days before they are needed to allow adequate processing time, particularly for materials requiring conversion from print to accessible digital formats.

8. Conduct, Fines, and Lost Materials

Patrons are expected to handle library materials and facilities responsibly. Items reported lost are billed at replacement cost plus a \$15 processing fee. Registration holds are placed on student accounts with fines exceeding \$50 or with overdue materials past 60 days, preventing course registration and transcript release until resolved.

Note: Financial holds related to library fines may be appealed through the Library Fines Appeal Committee, which meets biweekly during the academic year.

9. Frequently Asked Questions

Can community members borrow books?

Community borrowing cards are available for an annual fee and provide access to circulating collections, though not to electronic journal subscriptions, which are licensed for current students, faculty, and staff only.

What happens if I lose a library laptop?

Lost or stolen equipment must be reported to Access Services within 24 hours. The borrower is responsible for the full replacement cost, though a payment plan may be arranged through Student Accounts.

How do I request a book the Library doesn't own?

Use the Interlibrary Loan request form in the library catalog; most requests are fulfilled from partner institutions within the standard 5–10 business day turnaround.

10. Related Policies and Resources

This policy should be read in conjunction with other governing University policies, including the University Catalog, the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) Notice, and any college- or department-specific handbooks that supplement, but do not contradict, the standards set out here. Where a conflict exists between this policy and a college-level document, this policy governs unless an explicit written exception has been approved by the Provost's Office.

- University Catalog (undergraduate and graduate editions), published annually
- FERPA Notice of Student Rights, available through the Office of the Registrar
- Student Handbook, distributed at orientation and available online
- College- and department-specific supplemental guidelines, where applicable

11. Contact and Further Assistance

Questions regarding the interpretation or application of this policy should be directed to the University Libraries Access Services. Students are encouraged to reach out early in the process, as many concerns can be resolved informally before they require a formal procedure.

Contact Point	Detail
Office	University Libraries Access Services
Email	libraryhelp@meridianstate.edu
Phone	(555) 201-4420
Office Hours	Monday–Friday, 8:30 a.m. – 5:00 p.m.
Walk-in Location	Student Services Building, Suite 200

12. Policy Revision History

Version	Date	Summary of Changes
1.0	August 2021	Initial policy adopted by the Board of Trustees.
1.1	August 2023	Clarified procedural timelines and appeal deadlines.
2.0	August 2025	Comprehensive revision to align with updated accreditation standards.
2.1	August 2026	Minor updates for the current academic year; see effective date above.

Note: This document supersedes all prior versions upon its effective date. Archived versions are available upon request from the issuing office.